# PRELUDE XIV

THE player who can best appreciate Milton's enormous verse-paragraphs with their perfect articulation that provides abundant breathing space without checking the flow, will have the best chance of giving a good account of this magnificent stream of lyric melody. Before breaking it up into short themes he should view it in its largest aspects, and should cultivate an ambition ultimately to carry the listener with him in one flight from the beginning to the close into bar 12, and even then to feel the desire to go on with the counter-statement and development. Meanwhile the important half-close in bar 7 will be obvious enough; and there will be no danger of thinking and playing as if the piece consisted of one-bar themes merely because the middle voice answers the upper in bar 2.

With use of a large *cantabile* tone it is possible and desirable to maintain almost an *Adagio tempo* which might be risky in a less terse and concentrated trio of this type. The *Andante* of the Italian Concerto (which is full of demisemiquavers) is about the same *tempo*, likewise the thirteenth of the Goldberg Variations. (The twenty-fifth Goldberg Variation would be slower.) At all events, in this Prelude the distinction between demisemiquavers and triplet semiquavers should be naturally expressive. In this respect, as in all others, the British Museum autograph represents for this Prelude a slower *tempo* and a finer harmonic edge than the Altnikol MSS., which give readings whereby the moving parts timidly anticipate the changes of key so as to avoid false relations. The D♮ in the third crotchet of bar 26 and the G♯ in that of bar 33 beautifully illustrate the value of a slow *tempo* to deepen the harmony; likewise still more subtly the reading of the autograph in the bass of bar 18, where every other MS. brings the D♯ to the third crotchet. Only in bar 8 is Kirnberger's MS. evidently finer than the autograph, which reads a tied A instead of B in the left hand middle voice.

# FUGUE XIV

THIS Fugue works out three Subjects in a plan obviously generally resembling that of the C♯ minor Fugue in Book I.; and the Third Subject here reminds the listener strongly of the Second Subject of the C♯ minor. The differences are more profound than the resemblances, though the moods are not unlike. In spite of its often extremely involved five-part texture the C♯ minor Fugue emphasises its entries and keeps its Episodes apart in the background so long as it retains leisure for Episodes at all. Also its Subjects are short, the flowing quaver subject attaining length by running in one voice over two entries of the other Subjects. In the present Fugue, in spite of the most transparent three-part writing, the real entries of the Subjects are continually masked by counterpoints that imitate and anticipate their figures. Thus, in the pathetic and lyrically expressive exposition of the Second Subject, beginning at the sixth quaver of bar 20, the middle voice intervenes with a merely imitative entry between the Subject in the bass and its Answer in the treble. Before it answers in its turn it has inserted another imitation of the figure, and its real Answer (in the middle of bar 22) is in the boldly ultra-subdominant region of E minor. The following entry of the bass (bar 24) in A major (carrying on the sequence of keys) is less masked, but now echoes of the First Subject steal in; so that the fully formed combination of the two (First Subject in middle part, beginning on last quaver of bar 28; Second Subject in bass, beginning on second quaver of bar 30) is the end of a fascinating process taking shape through the clouds. Already in the Exposition of the First Subject the



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line between Episode and Subject was mysterious. The first three notes of the Subject were transparently enough (though closely) developed by inversion as well as directly in Episode 1 (bars 11½-16), but these three notes gathered strength in the broad sequence of the bass in bars 13-16, insomuch that the second step of that sequence was hardly to be distinguished from the whole Subject.

The complete combination of the two Subjects in bars 29-31 stands alone; for the following complete entry of the First Subject in the bass in C♯ minor (bars 34-36) is accompanied only by the broken figures of the Second. On the other hand, the Third Subject enters in the middle voice at the last moment (bar 36), and is answered at a single bar's distance by the other voices in a drifting sequence of keys. Like the Second Subject of the C♯ minor Fugue of Book I., it is a coiling figure which can be drawn out *ad libitum*, and the resemblance of treatment extends to the inversion in bars 47-48. But, unlike the Second Subject of the C♯ minor Fugue, this Third Subject is left almost entirely to itself for a long time; the echoes of the First Subject (bars 41-43, inverted first figure; 46-etc., quaver and crotchet incidents) being faint and scattered. At last they gather in one anticipating bar, to usher a middle-voice entry of the First Subject in the subdominant (occupying bars 52-54). The treble, in the course of an ornamental flow, drifts into the Answer in F♯ minor in bar 55, and now all three Subjects are combined. It may help the student to see the combination reduced to the schematic essentials of its prototype in the C♯ minor Fugue, premising that it is by no means the player's or listener's business to disregard the matrix from which the definite combination emerges, but rather to make the whole process a *crescendo* of creative power.




* This trill given by Bach during the Exposition can, of course, be supplied wherever playable.

From bar 55 to the end the Fugue is occupied with a statement of three permutations (out of the possible six) of this Triple Counterpoint, separated by two short Episodes.

The *tempo* is pretty exactly that of the great C♯ minor Fugue, making the present quavers equal to the C♯ minor's crotchets. The tendency to hurry between bars 36 and 52 must be restrained without being violently destroyed; it being an instinct not to be ignored, and the effect of a compensating broadening at the formation of the Triple Counterpoint being, within the limits of sublety, desirable and appropriate. There is plenty of room for full tone, both in the Exposition and in the climax. Probably nobody will fail to see the need for contrast of quiet lyric pathos in the exposition of the Second Subject (bars 20-26).